

文 法 Grammar

1 ~んです

There are two distinct ways to make a statement in Japanese. One way is to simply report the facts as they are observed. This is the mode of speech that we have learned so far. In this lesson, we will learn a new way: the mode of *explaining* things.

short form (verbs/adjectives/nouns) + んです
= explanation in terms of the verbs/adjectives/nouns

When you are late for an appointment, because the bus did not come on time, you could simply and bluntly report the fact by saying バスが来ませんでした, but you can sound more apologetic if you offer that as an *explanation* for your being late. You can say:

バスが来なかったんです。 (As it happens,) the bus didn't come.

An explanation therefore connects a fact (the bus not coming), to another element in the situation under discussion (you being late for the appointment). The sentence-final expression んです serves as the link between what the sentence says and what it accounts for. Compare:

あしたテストがあります。 I have an exam tomorrow. (a simple observation)

あしたテストがあるんです。 I have an exam tomorrow. (So I can't go out tonight.)

トイレに行きたいです。 I want to go to the bathroom. (declaration of one's wish)

トイレに行きたいんです。 I want to go to the bathroom. (So tell me where it is.)

んです itself is invariant and does not usually appear in the negative or the past tense forms,¹ but the predicate before it can be affirmative or negative, present tense or past tense.

成績がよくないんです。 (in response to the question "Why do you look so upset?")

(As a matter of fact) My grade is not good.

試験が終わったんです。 (explaining to a person who has caught you smiling)

The exam is over. (That's why I'm smiling.)

¹ In casual exchanges, んです appears in its short form, んだ. In casual questions, んですか is replaced by の. We will examine these further in Lesson 15.

When it follows a noun or a な-adjective in the present tense affirmative, な comes in between.

	report sentences	explanation sentences
な-adjectives:	静かです しずか	静かなんです しずかな
nouns:	学生です がくせい	学生なんです がくせい

You can use んです in questions to invite clarifications from the person you are talking to. It is very often used together with question words, such as どうして (why) and どうした (what has happened).

A : どうして彼と別れたんですか。

Why did you break up with your boyfriend? (You've got to tell me.)

B : 彼、ぜんぜんお風呂に入らないんです。

Oh, him. He never takes a bath. (That's a good enough reason, isn't it?)

A : どうしたんですか。

What happened? (You look shattered.)

B : うちの猫が死んだんです。²

My cat died. (That should explain how I look today.)

You can also use んです to provide an additional comment on what has just been said.

A : かわいいノートですね。

That's a cute notebook.

B : ええ。日本で買ったんです。

You bet. I bought it in Japan (for your information).

In the written language, you see のです instead of んです. It has the same functions but is stylistically more formal.

² A どうしたんですか question is best answered by a んです sentence with the subject marked with the particle が rather than は, as in this example. See Lesson 8 for a related discussion.

2 ～すぎる

Verb stems may be followed by the helping verb **すぎる**, which means “too much,” or “to excess.” **すぎる** conjugates as a regular *ru*-verb.

早く起きすぎました。
はや お

I got up too early.

食べすぎてはいけません。
た

You must not eat too much.

すぎる can also follow *い*- and *な*-adjective bases (the parts which do not change in conjugations); you drop the *い* and *な* at the end of the adjectives and then add **すぎる**.³

(高い) この本は高すぎます。
たかほん たか

This book is too expensive.

(静かな) この町は静かすぎます。
しず まち しず

This town is too quiet.

verb stem/adjective stem + **すぎる** . . . *too much*

You use **すぎる** when something is beyond normal or proper, suggesting that you do not welcome it. Thus **親切すぎます** (too kind) for example is not a straightforward compliment. Use modifiers like **とても** and **すごく** if you simply want to say that something is in a high degree.

3 ～ほうがいいです

ほうがいいです “it is better (for you) to do . . .” is a sentence-final expression which you can use to give advice. **ほうがいいです** follows a verb in the short form. You usually use the past tense of a verb with **ほうがいいです** if the verb is in the affirmative. When the advice is in the negative, however, the verb is in the *present* tense.

verb (short, past, affirmative)	} + ほうがいいです	<i>It is better.</i>
verb (short, present, negative)		<i>It is better not . . .</i>

もっと野菜を食べたほうがいいですよ。
やさい た

You'd better eat more vegetables.

授業を休まないほうがいいですよ。
じゅぎょう やす

It is better not to skip classes.

³ In addition to the verb conjugation, we also use the noun **すぎ**, as in **食べすぎです**.

4 ~ので

You can use **ので** to give the reason for the situation described in the balance of the sentence. Semantically, **ので** is very similar to **から**. Stylistically, **ので** sounds slightly more formal than **から** and is used extensively in the written language.

(reason) ので (situation). (situation), because (reason).

いつも日本語で話すので、日本語が上手になりました。

My Japanese has improved, because I always speak Japanese.

宿題がたくさんあったので、きのうの夜、寝ませんでした。

I did not sleep last night, because I had a lot of homework.

The reason part of a **ので** sentence usually is in a short form. When **ので** follows a な-adjective or a noun in a present tense affirmative clause, な comes in between, as it did with the explanatory predicate **んです**.

その人はいじわるなので、きらいです。 (Compare: いじわるだから)

I do not like that person, because he is mean.

今日は日曜日なので、銀行は休みです。 (Compare: 日曜日だから)

Banks are closed, because today is a Sunday.

5 ~なければいけません / ~なきゃいけません

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L12

We use **なければいけません** and **なきゃいけません**⁴ to say that it is necessary to do something, or “must.” The **なければ** variant is more formal and often seen in the written language, while the **なきゃ** variant is very colloquial and is mainly found in the spoken language.

試験があるから、勉強しなければいけません / なきゃいけません。

I have to study, because there will be an exam.

⁴ There are more varieties for “must” sentences: **なくちゃいけません**, **なくてはいけません**, and **ないと いけません**. You can also substitute **なりません** for **いけません** in the **なければ** and **なきゃ** combinations, like **なければなりません**, **なきゃなりません**.

なければ and なきゃ mean “if you do not do . . .” and いけません roughly means “you cannot go”; なければいけません and なきゃいけません therefore literally mean “you cannot go not doing . . .” with the double negatives giving rise to the affirmative sense of the mandate. な in なければ and なきゃ comes from the negative ない. Just drop the last い and replace it with ければ or きゃ.

verb	short negative	“must”
食べる たべる	食べ <u>ない</u> たべない	食べ <u>なければいけません</u> / 食べ <u>なきゃいけません</u> たべなければいけません / たべなきゃいけません
言う いう	言わ <u>ない</u> いわない	言わ <u>なければいけません</u> / 言わ <u>なきゃいけません</u> いわなければいけません / いわなきゃいけません
する	し <u>ない</u>	し <u>なければいけません</u> / し <u>なきゃいけません</u>
くる	こ <u>ない</u>	こ <u>なければいけません</u> / こ <u>なきゃいけません</u>

You can change いけません to いけませんでした to say you *had to*. You can use the short form なきゃいけない in casual speech. You can further shorten it to just なきゃ.

けさは、六時に起きなきゃいけませんでした。(long form, past)
ろくじ お

I had to get up at six this morning.

彼女が来るから、部屋を掃除しなきゃ(いけない)。(short form, present)
かのじょ く へや そうじ

I must clean the room, because my girlfriend is coming.

6 ～でしょうか

If you ask somebody a question that they do not know the answer to, they may be embarrassed. You can avoid such awkward situations by phrasing the question using でしょうか, which adds a note of tentativeness and politeness.

A: あした、雨が降るでしょうか。
あめ ふ

Would it rain tomorrow?

B: 降ると思います。
ふ おも

I think it will.

でしょう means *probably*. By asking a でしょうか question, you are implying that you think the listener probably has a better-informed opinion, which you would appreciate.

でしょう follows short form predicates (affirmative or negative, present or past). When it follows a noun or a な-adjective in a present tense affirmative sentence, it directly follows them, without だ in between.

来週は暖かいでしょうか。

らいしゅう あた

Would you say that it will be warm next week?

トマトは野菜でしょうか。 (× 野菜~~だ~~でしょうか)

やさい

やさい

Is a tomato a vegetable?

これ、もう話したでしょうか。

はな

Have I told you about this already?

You can use the non-interrogative **でしょう** to make a guess. You can add **たぶん** earlier in the sentence to signal that it is a guess.⁵

たぶんあしたは寒くないでしょう。

さむ

I bet it will not be cold tomorrow.

Expression Notes

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表現ノート

ひょうげん

うーん ▶ **うーん**, with the prolonged *u* syllable, indicates reflection and hesitation. It is often used when you cannot make up your mind or when you are about to give an answer which may be unfavorable to the person you are talking with.

A: 結婚してください。

けっこん

B: うーん、まだ結婚したくないんです。もう少し待ってください。

けっこん

すこま

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⁵ In casual exchanges, you can use **でしょう** (with the question intonation, and most often pronounced as somewhat shorter **でしょ**) when you want to check if your partner agrees that you have the correct understanding about what you have just said.

ジョン、中国語がわかるでしょ? これ、読んで。

ちゅうごくご

John, you understand Chinese, right? Can you read this for me?